

Santiago (Tigo) Ponce de León

Product Design Engineer — Chicago, Illinois

A designer who ships the code — research and product thinking through to React in production, in service of software that is both useful and pleasurable.

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Experience

- 01

Vicino AI — UX Engineer Intern

Jun 2026 - Aug 2026

Bellevue, WA

 - Designing product experiences across key workflows for an AI-powered video and marketing platform, turning agentic creative concepts into user-centered interfaces.
 - Building front-end UI components in React, bridging Figma designs and production code to accelerate design-to-engineer handoff.
 - Shaping and documenting the platform's visual language and interaction patterns into a scalable component library used across feature pages.
- 02

PantryPal — Product Designer and iOS Developer

Nov 2025 - Present

Chicago, IL

 - Designing and building an AI mobile app that turns the ingredients a household already owns into personalized recipes, cutting food waste through inventory reuse.
 - Writing the production iOS app in Swift and SwiftUI — designing and coding the same screens — with an App Store release targeted for August 2026.
 - Ran user interviews and moderated usability tests between design rounds, rebuilding ingredient entry and recipe matching around where people actually got stuck.
 - Built the design system behind the app: wireframes through high-fidelity UI, a documented component library, and interaction patterns now implemented in SwiftUI.
- 03

University of Chicago — UX Researcher

Nov 2025 - Dec 2025

Chicago, IL

 - Ran an empirical study of visual and interaction patterns across six AI-generated recipe web apps to measure interface homogenization.
 - Deployed prototypes via GitHub Pages and authored the paper on how AI models operationalize a statistical consensus of product design convention.
- 04

Next Level Drone Cleaning — Founding Visual Designer

Jul 2025 - Sep 2025

Kortrijk, Belgium

 - Designed the complete visual identity for an early-stage drone-tech startup from scratch: brand guidelines, logo suite, and collateral across web, print, and pitch.
 - Built the responsive marketing site (nextleveldronecleaning.be) with the founder, plus component libraries that held the team consistent without ongoing design help.

Education

- University of Chicago — B.A. Media Arts & Design and Computer Science

Expected May 2027

Chicago, IL

Coursework: Human-Computer Interaction, Internet Art & Web Design, Visual Systems

Honors: Spain Foreign Language Acquisition Grant — study in Madrid, Summer 2025

Skills

- product

User Research

Wireframing

Interaction Design

Design Systems

Usability Testing
- engineering

Swift

SwiftUI

React

HTML / CSS / JavaScript

Python

C#

Git

Xcode
- design

Figma

Prototyping

Adobe Creative Cloud
- languages

Spanish — professional working

English — fluent